

The elder brother who backed talent unconditionally

Paras Dogra — or Paras *bhaiya*, as he is affectionately called — fostered a **culture of inclusiveness**, and the results were there for all to see.

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A couple of years ago, Paras Dogra received a call that could have altered the course of his career.

On the other end was an old friend, a former India cricketer, with some practical advice: after two decades in domestic cricket — 16 seasons with Himachal Pradesh and six as a professional with Pondicherry — perhaps it was time to move on.

There was a lucrative offer from a prominent legends' league featuring retired players. The money was good. The grind would be lighter. The future, secure.

Dogra listened. But he was torn.

The hunger to compete in India's premier domestic tournament still burned bright. Yet the road ahead seemed uncertain.

In the middle of that dilemma, he dialled another number, that of Mithun Manhas.

That conversation changed everything.

Manhas, then the cricket director at the Jammu and Kashmir Cricket Association, urged Dogra not to give up on mainstream cricket. Instead, he offered him a fresh challenge — the role of guest player-cum-captain for the Jammu and Kashmir team.

After days of deliberation, Dogra said yes.

In 2024, when he took charge, he could not have

imagined that two years later he would guide J&K to its maiden Ranji Trophy title. Initially, though, the appointment sparked controversy. A section of the cricket fraternity questioned whether his perceived closeness to Manhas had tilted the scales in his favour.

Dogra let his bat, and leadership, respond.

"Initially, the runs were not coming. So, of course, the pressure was mounting. But somehow, I was enjoying this new journey with the bunch of boys," he tells *Sportstar*.

Integration was his first task. He made it a point to involve everyone.

"I took advice even from the youngest member of the team. Before every innings, we would get into a huddle: seniors, juniors, everyone spoke. Every opinion was valued."

That culture of inclusiveness began to reflect in performances. Under the watchful eye of head coach Ajay Sharma, preparation standards rose. P. Krishnakumar and Dishant Yagnik brought